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As anyone who has ever lived in central Iowa knows, winters there can last forever and slip into the heat of summer with barely a nod to spring. After I started broadcasting the Cubs' games, I concocted a plan to escape part of the frigid Iowa winter by offering to accompany the team to its annual spring training camp in California. If you will pay my expenses, I told the people at WHO, I'll go to California and donate my yearly vacation to the cause, and the trip will pay off in color and knowledge about the team I'll be able to use all through the coming season.

The proposal, which they accepted, wasn't as charitable on my part as it seemed: A baseball announcer never gets to take a vacation during the summer, and my plan gave me an all-expense-paid holiday under the California sun, along with a chance to earn some extra money by writing articles for the newspapers back home. Since I also broadcast games of the Chicago White Sox, I could also look in on their spring practice in Pasadena, a few miles from Los Angeles.

The Cubs, owned by the Wrigley chewing gum family, did their spring training on Catalina, a rocky island off the coast of Southern California that was also owned by the family.

My annual trips to Southern California began in 1935. For someone who'd practically cut his teeth on celluloid shoot-'em-ups and carried around fantasies about becoming an actor for years, Catalina was tantalizingly close to Hollywood, but it was also pretty remote. Every week, there were hundreds of young people—from Iowa, Illinois, and just about every other state—who stepped off a train at Union Station in Los Angeles who had exactly the same dream that